DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Why Must the Body Die Before It Is Perfected?

Daat Tevunot §72

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §72 (first half)
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These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we left off

Section 4 discusses the relationship between body and soul: the essence of man, his actions, and their consequences. The Ramhal began with tehiyat hametim, because in his view the final reward belongs to body and soul together: the body toiled, so it must also be rewarded, though it will be a different kind of body.

We also learned why God fused the two: so that there would be a tug of war between them, and the soul, through good deeds, would refine and elevate the body. In principle, a person who does God's will and subdues his animal drives should go straight to olam haba. The Rabbi reminded the group that olam haba is not the world of souls after death, which is Gan Eden, but "the real eternity". So why does that not happen?

The sin of Adam made death necessary

The Ramhal answers: the sin caused it. Before the sin of Adam, a person who did what was right would have had his body refined by his soul automatically, and the two would have lived together for eternity, with the body submissive to the soul. After the sin, the soul can no longer complete this refinement without death.

That, the Rabbi explained, is the meaning of the saying of Hazal that four people died only because of the counsel of the serpent. They had refined themselves enough that their souls could have elevated their bodies, but because of the sin of Adam, which goes back to the serpent's advice, even they had to pass through death.

How death helps

When the body returns to the dust and decomposes, the pollution in it diminishes. The Rabbi added a point he said is made in Derech Hashem: while the soul is in the body its wings are clipped. After death it is free, and in the world of souls, "the waiting room", which is a wonderful place though nothing like olam haba, it is nourished by the higher light.

When it returns at the resurrection, it comes back with all that strength and ignites a great light in the body. The body is not only healed but elevated into a different entity. "It will be our

bodies, our hands, our limbs, but not that body which we have nowadays." No tiredness, no aches, no impulses, no nagging hunger.

Asked whether all bodies will then be equal, the Rabbi said every body that enters olam haba will be purified of everything bad. But how much your identity and consciousness can relate to God depends on your misvot and Torah. A person who has olam haba for one good deed and a complete saddik are not alike, though both bodies will be elevated. One sits in the royal box, another in the top row of the stadium.

The two periods, and the Rambam

The Ramhal describes the two periods of a person's existence. Now the body is thick and dark, and the soul's task is to fill it with as much light as possible. When that time ends, the time of reward begins, and together they enjoy eternity. Where is olam haba? "Right here," the Rabbi said: body and soul, you and me. Gan Eden in between is the soul alone, and it is nothing compared to the real reward.

Is that body physical, something you can touch? Here the Ramhal and the Rambam disagree. For the Rambam, who thought in Aristotle's terms, physicality contradicts spirituality, so there can be no body in the world to come. For the Ramhal there is a body, but a refined one. That is why the Rabbi thinks they are not so far apart: the Rambam might accept a body of the Ramhal's kind.

He added that the Rambam has a real difficulty here. If the world to come is soul alone, why is resurrection needed at all? When people in his time accused him of denying resurrection, the Rambam wrote his essay on tehiyat hametim to respond. There he affirms resurrection, but says that those resurrected will die again. "Why on earth do you need that? That is a question which I don't have an answer to." That is why some believe the Rambam did not hold of resurrection in our sense, or read it as a metaphor for the soul living on.

A soul reduced like the moon

The Ramhal now explains the measure of the soul's power. If the soul entered the body with its full power, it would immediately perfect it and there would be no free choice and no reward or punishment, just as angels have no yeser hara because they are full of light. Of the future it says that the earth will be full of knowledge and "I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh". But if the soul came in too weak, it could not withstand this world. So God reduces its light to create a level playing field between body and soul.

The Rabbi noted that the full soul enters only around twelve or thirteen, which is why young children are so selfish and impulsive.

The Ramhal compares this to the moon, which was made smaller and will in the future shine like the sun. So too the soul is reduced now, lives in the body all its days and fights its temptations. According to what it actually does, it "merits", and the Rabbi stressed that word, to rise level by level. At the time of reward its full potential is released, and it elevates the body completely at the resurrection, to enjoy eternity.

Questions about the soul

Are all souls reduced equally? The Rabbi thought not, and that this is taken into account. Someone born into a family of murderers who only steals may stand higher than someone born into a family of great scholars who abandons Torah and Shabbat, as they had learned in Derech Hashem, where each person has a different role in the King's palace.

Why are some people like beasts? Not because their soul is weak, but "because you haven't trained your soul to control your body". Without the soul any of us would eat like an animal.

What is the soul? The Rabbi said the Neshamah is not a magical thing inside you; it is your consciousness, your identity. Almost every organ can be transplanted, but not the brain, because the consciousness in it is who you are. Using the five levels of the soul they learned in Derech Hashem, he explained that the lowest, the nefesh habehemit, which every living creature has, says "I want food, I want money", while the higher levels say no. "So the conflict is within the soul."

Summary

- Before the sin of Adam, good deeds alone would have let the soul refine the body; after it, even the righteous must pass through death.
- In death the body's pollution decays, and the soul is strengthened in the world of souls; at the resurrection it returns with full light and elevates the body.
- Olam haba is body and soul together; the Rabbi sees the Ramhal and the Rambam as closer than they appear, while noting the Rambam's difficulty in explaining resurrection.
- The soul is reduced on entering the body, like the moon, so that free choice is possible; what it achieves now determines how fully it will elevate the body later.
- The soul is our consciousness, and the battle with the nefesh habehemit is fought within it.

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